

Origin of a champion: Aman is a product of the Chhatrasal akhara, a training centre as important to Indian wrestling as La Masia is to Spanish football. REUTERS

here. Now people also know that this is my mentality. I don't like roaming around or going around Delhi either," Aman says.

As the years passed in Chhatrasal, Aman slowly made a name for himself, even in this school of champions. He made his way through the nationals, winning gold in 2022. He even started making a mark at the international level, becoming India's first U-23 World Champion in 2022 and then winning an Asian Championship gold in 2023.

His exploits earned him the only real concession Chhatrasal provides its best athletes — a prefabricated room that he only has to share with two others. It has its own AC, though. On one of the walls, Aman has put up a hand-painted poster of the Olympic rings. Below it — in English — are the words, 'If it was easy, everyone would do it'.

While he was dreaming of the Olympics, he had to get through his biggest challenge yet: fellow Chhatrasal trainee Ravi, the Tokyo silver medallist. After two losses, Aman finally beat his senior rival at the Olympic selection trials in March this year.

Then came the Asian Olympic qualifiers. But he missed out on the quota there, and there was no point in sulking. He dove into preparation for the World Olympic qualifiers, won the quota, and thereafter, the right to compete in Paris.

At the Olympics, Aman was placed

in a tough group.

However, he once again did what he knew he must do on the mat and off it. By the time he was done, he had, as a memento, a raw cut on the bridge of his nose to go with the bronze medal around his neck.

The cut will heal, but the medal, Aman says, will not satisfy him.

Life will not change that much. He says he'll go back to the same room he shares with two other athletes. He'll continue to train as he's always done. The only change is his dreams.

"I'm going to win a gold medal next time," he says.

AMAN JOINED AN ELITE LIST OF INDIAN MEN'S OLYMPIC WRESTLING MEDALLISTS, WHICH INCLUDES SUSHIL KUMAR, YOGESHWAR DUTT, RAVI DAHIYA AND BAJRANG PUNIA